

building, resilience, annual collaboration, and strategic planning.”

Underpinning all these initiatives is the leveraging of technology to streamline processes. In 2020, Abbott launched SmaHRty, an AI-powered HR chatbot that provides instant answers to employee queries about policies and benefits. “We empower our teams with innovative digital tools for a seamless employee experience and realised efficiencies. The chatbot enables the HR team to be more productive with their time by streamlining, automating, and accelerating the process of resolving employees’ queries,” says Mukerji.

To reflect the communities Abbott serves, it has laid emphasis on diversity, equity, and inclusion initiatives. Mukerji says, “As part of our global 2030 Sustainability Plan, we shared our goal to achieve gender balance across our global management team with at least 45% female representation.” Programmes like the Women Leaders of Abbott (WLA) create a network of female employees and provide access to mentors, networking opportunities, and resources for professional development. Additionally, initiatives like “Happy Feet” are intended to provide a supportive environment for working mothers returning from maternity leave.

There’s also a programme specifically aimed at women returning from career breaks, the “Abbott Second Careers Engagement Program”, that reintegrates them into the workforce with flexibility. Additionally, it has a pipeline of future talent from underrepresented groups in STEM fields.

“Another example is the Working Mothers of Abbott forum, which provides support, guidance, experiential learning, and networking opportunities to support working



Key HR initiatives

- ▶ **Listening Strategy:** It conducts a survey, called “Your Voice Counts” to seek employee feedback
- ▶ **Clara Abbott Foundation:** It offers expert guidance free of charge, helping families achieve financial independence
- ▶ **India Wellness Strategy:** Known as BeStrong, the programme addresses the core aspects of physical, emotional, financial, and social wellness
- ▶ **Flexible Benefits Programme:** It offers employees the flexibility to choose benefits that align with their life stages and priorities

mothers. The aim is to provide the means for women to enhance their talent and develop professionally,” says Mukerji.

To foster an inclusive environment, Abbott also has employee networks like PRIDE and disABILITY that provide safe spaces for LGBTQ+ and differently-abled employees to connect, collaborate, and advocate for themselves.

The company implements in-depth talent management practices to identify and develop successors for critical roles. This ensures a smooth transition and continued leadership.

With over 12,000 employees, Abbott’s India employee strength is second only to the US one. It believes its dedication to employee growth and well-being has translated into healthy business results. The revenue of Abbott India, the listed entity, grew 9.2% year-over-year (YoY) to ₹1,437 crore in Q3FY24, while its net profit jumped 26% YoY to ₹311 crore. The listed entity only accounts for a part of the pharma business. Other businesses, including nutrition, devices and diagnostics, are part of privately held companies.

Considering its results, Abbott’s focus on its employees might become an example for others to follow. **BT**

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